To Fly Without Arriving

Ardent or effaced, different but together,
turning from the stars whose nature is to fly without arriving.
—René Char, "Les Parages d'Alsace"

The first time I saw that roller coaster, I was in first grade. Back at that time I went to Universal Studios Japan in Osaka with my mom. It was so long ago that I barely remember anything. But I do remember the blue sphere at the park gate, and that right after you enter, you can see a really tall roller coaster, and faintly hear screams drifting over. Back then I wanted to ride it so badly, but I was only 1.1 meters tall—I didn't meet the height requirement—so I had to give up.

This summer I traveled around Kansai with two of my closest friends, Mandy and Daniel, and we went to Universal again. When I planned our route through the park, I deliberately set aside time for that coaster—kind of fulfilling a childhood wish.

The coaster is called "Hollywood Dream." I've always been puzzled by that—why name something that looks so intense a "dream"? We use the same word for the thing worth spending every last drop of your life on—and for what merely flickers behind your eyelids during REM sleep, illusory and brief, barely retrievable once you're awake. I didn't know which kind they meant. I wasn't sure it mattered.

We queued for ages. By the time we finally got on, it was probably around five or six in the evening. The sun was setting, and the sky was a clean, bright blue. There are speakers on both sides of the headrest that play music during the ride, and there's a button on one side of the handle where you can choose a track. We all picked the default song, "Osaka Lover"—apparently it's also one of those signature Osaka vibe songs. With the drumbeat of the intro, the train began to climb slowly. I sank back into the seat, my gaze running along the long stretch of track and dropping straight into that blue sky. Mandy asked me, voice shaking, if I was nervous. I told her that in my experience, raising your arms during the drop actually makes the weightlessness feel less intense—you can try it.

After that, all my memories come in fragments. I only remember the chorus melody mixing with the wind howling past my ears; the screams and laughter of my friends right beside me; our arms thrown up high, occasionally bumping into each other when the train turned. So it turns out people really do cry when they're happy to the absolute extreme. And for a long time to come, I might never experience a moment this happy again. In that instant, I suddenly thought: in this unbelievably joyful moment, with my very best friends around me—if I were to die here, right now, for basically any random reason, it somehow wouldn't be completely unacceptable. Like how a movie should roll the credits right at the climax, I instinctively wanted my life to end at its most complete moment. My tears were blown backward by the wind from the outer corner of my eye, and then simply disappeared. As the train began to slow down, the music gradually

faded too, and over the broadcast at the end of the track came a line: “Everyone’s dreams will definitely come true!”

From that moment on, I understood why this coaster is a “dream.” And I also decided I would use the visible, remaining years of my life to remember this minute and a half.

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On the last day of our trip, we went shopping in downtown Osaka. Because Airbnb required us to check out in the morning, we had to haul all our luggage with us. To make life easier, we found a set of coin lockers inside the station and dumped our bags there.

We wandered around together until about 1 p.m. Mandy was heading to Tokyo the next day by Shinkansen, then flying straight back to the U.S. Daniel and I, on the other hand, were catching a 3:30 p.m. flight back to Hongkong. After hugs and goodbyes, Daniel and I started making our way back.

And then–we got lost. Inside the massive labyrinth that is Umeda Station, we could no longer find the very lockers where we had left our luggage. The bags were somewhere in the right place. We, unfortunately, were not.

Trying to locate a coin locker in a city’s main transit hub two and a half hours before an international flight, when getting to the airport alone would take at least an hour–this is a scenario that somehow manages to cram an impressive number of words I deeply dislike into a single sentence. Still, we had no choice, and we began the search.

Our first move was to find a station map. This, as it turned out, was an act of pure optimism. Because Umeda Station is not a normal subway station. Three different subway lines intersect in the same neighborhood, yet belong to three different stations–Umeda, Western-Umeda, and Eastern-Umeda–because apparently naming things clearly was never the goal. And as if that weren’t enough, looming over everything is JR Umeda Station: the largest, the most confusing, and the one most likely to make you question your life decisions.

But as long-time travel companions, Daniel and I were both emotionally as stable as capybaras in moments like this. That was hardly surprising because we went to high school together–if you manage to graduate from a Chinese high school with your sanity intact, your mental state tends to remain impressively resilient no matter what comes after.

So we started moving through the station, one corridor after another. We relied on vague memories and blind faith, chasing any path that looked like something we might have walked past before. The problem was that every hallway felt familiar. You’d turn a corner and find an even more familiar one. Just when you felt destiny was about to guide you to the correct place, you’d realize you were standing exactly where you had entered the station seven minutes ago. Daniel also tried using his “I passed N3” Japanese to ask a station staff member where the coin lockers were. But, like I said, coin lockers are basically the one thing Umeda Station will never

run out of. You take two steps and–congrats–there's another set. So when that handsome guy at the information counter glanced at the coin lockers sitting right next to us, then looked back to us with an expression usually reserved for the truly hopeless, we collectively decided that asking for directions was no longer a viable strategy.

We wandered around the many parallel universes of Umeda Station for about forty minutes, circling between the four stations, ducking from indoors to outdoors and back again. At our most desperate, we briefly considered splitting up. Then we thought it through. If the luggage and a person got lost, that would be an even bigger disaster. So we abandoned that idea immediately. At some point we stumbled out into the open, and the 2 p.m. sun hit us full in the face—absurdly, offensively bright. The sky was that same stupid, perfect blue. Around us, salarymen in wilted suits shuffled through crosswalks with the resigned grace of men who had long stopped asking where they were going. A group of middle-aged women stormed past us toward a department store with a ferocity that suggested the entire building might be 80% off. And here we were, two idiots with no luggage, no sense of direction, and a flight in two hours, squinting up at the sky like it owed us an explanation. I wanted to punch the sun out of it. Instead I just stood there, sweating, and thought: god, what a disgustingly beautiful day. Every single one of us out here is just trying so hard to be alive.

At the very end of our rope, it suddenly hit me: my iPad was in the suitcase. And I could locate it with Apple's Find My app. Daniel declared me a genius on the spot. The plan was approved and executed without delay. When we finally stepped into the correct–and unmistakably familiar–white-and-green corridor, and saw that row of familiar lockers, my sense of pride surpassed even the joy of getting an A+ in linear algebra last year.

So we sprinted straight onto the express train to the airport. We spent the entire ride sitting there in silent panic. The moment the train stopped, we launched ourselves out of the car and bolted for security. Thankfully, we had already checked in online on the subway. Bless modern technology.

At security, we did the usual ritual of opening our bags. That was when life decided to keep things interesting. We had bought a generous supply of alcohol for a party the night before, and two large bottles of shochu were sitting completely forgotten at the very bottom of my backpack.

But in Chinese culture, wasting food or drink is basically a moral crime. Pouring two full bottles of shochu into the blue "liquids disposal" bin was unacceptable. So, under the intense gaze of the security officers and the surrounding crowd, we each grabbed a glass bottle, exchanged a bitter little toast, and then–like heroes marching to their doom–downed both bottles of shochu right there at the security checkpoint.

That was, without question, the fastest I have ever consumed alcohol in my life. Which is to say, I genuinely do not remember how the two of us then sprinted to the boarding gate at what

felt like the pace of a middle-school PE exam's 200-meter dash. All I remember is this: we arrived perfectly on time, dragging suitcases and backpacks, faces flushed and glowing with effort–and possibly shochu–only to see one word on the boarding gate screen:

"Delayed."

For two hours, by the way.

We laughed. What else was there to do?

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On the flight back to Hong Kong, Daniel fell asleep almost instantly—shochu and a full sprint through Kansai Airport will do that to a person. I stayed awake by the window and watched the sky outside shift from blue to purple to something in between.

We come from a subtropical coast. We met in high school—the most suffocating years of my life, though I refuse to say I'd redo them, because they gave me the friends I cannot do without. On those gray days we wore blue uniforms, and the campus faced the ocean: blue water, blue sky, blue everything, a world that insisted on being beautiful even when we were miserable in it. After graduation we started traveling together—Shuangyue Bay, Boston, New York, Shanghai, and now Osaka, one city after another, always moving, as if standing still might send us back to those hallways.

The plane was about to land in Shenzhen. Late August—still blazing hot. But the next time a plane I was on "landed," I would be in America, and autumn would be arriving. I hate autumn. Autumn is a rusted spring—its beauty flashes once and is gone, while what lingers is long, and rots alongside it. But it was only later that I realized: I hate autumn simply because its arrival means summer is over. And as it happens, every beautiful and precious memory I have ever lived through seems to have happened in summer. The beaches, the rain, the salt wind, the air that doesn't sting when you breathe it in—and always, always, those same few people showing up alongside the season. Maybe summer means more to me than I thought; maybe what I love was never really summer itself; and maybe, of all the seasons, my favorite is every one I've spent with them.

I've always said the meaning of travel is to seize the present. But in the roar of the plane's engines—and later, months afterward, when my playlist randomly lands on "Osaka Lover"—I still can't help asking: then what about yesterday? Can yesterday be replayed once more? And what about tomorrow? Can tomorrow be just as happy as before?